

hotspot allows connectivity of up to 32 devices, while Vodafone Wi-Fi hotspot allows connectivity of up to ten devices, at a single time.

Compatibility with the service provider. One important consideration when choosing between 3G and 4G technology is to check for coverage available in your area. If a 4G phone moves out of range of a 4G network, you will only receive 3G speeds. Think about the service provider you are going to use most of the time. Not every Internet service provider will have coverage in all areas and not every wireless device will be compatible with every service provider. So before you buy a portable Wi-Fi hotspot device, check if it is compatible with your SIM, USB datacard and the service provider.

Support for latest technology. While purchasing a Wi-Fi device it is important to check whether the device is compatible with future technology. Also check if the router supports a 3G/4G data card. For instance, Airtel modem supports 3G and LTE networks, whereas Idea Wi-Fi hub device is suited for HSPA+ speed up to 21.6Mbps DL and 11Mbps DL.

Wireless standards. For faster connections and high-speed Internet, one crucial thing to keep in mind is the wireless standards (802.11)-B, G and N. N is defined as the next-gen technology, is newer and supports faster speeds than wireless G. It can reach speeds up to 450Mbps with three antennae, while wireless G supports a maximum theoretical transfer rate of 54Mbps. Therefore N provides better range, better speed and better coverage than G. For example, Airtel 4G hotspot and Vodafone R206Z follow the latest wireless standards to stay ahead of its competition.

Device power source. A Wi-Fi router also acts as a power bank. What can be better than getting the advantage of two devices in one? Today, most of these devices double up as power banks and are available readily in the market. For example,

Huawei Wi-Fi E5730 comes with an inbuilt powerful battery of 5200mAh that not only gives continuous working time without the need to charge but also allows you to charge your smartphones and other devices on the go. Idea 3G Smart Wi-Fi hub comes with 1500mAh battery, while Vodafone R206 Z claims to get powerful portability with 3.75 hours of battery life.

Network security. Wi-Fi Protected Setup (WPS) is a network security standard that allows users to easily secure a wireless home network and allows them to connect wireless devices to the network without any loss of information. Almost all hotspot Wi-Fi devices offered by Airtel, Idea, Tata Photon, Vodafone and others support WPS for network security.

Data packages. High-speed connectivity comes at a high price. So it is crucial to select the right device based on data-usage packages offered by different service providers. Data plans for an instant Wi-Fi solution have been custom designed for intended target groups by different providers. For instance, MTS offers postpaid rental plan of, say, 10GB (5GB day and 5GB night, 3G+ network in Delhi region) data usage for ₹ 599, while Airtel provides 10GB (4G data at 3G prices) data usage plan for ₹ 1500.

The Internet has become an integral part of our daily life for staying connected with our friends, relatives and colleagues. It gives us the power to share what is important. Gone are the days of datacards when only one device could be accessed at a given time. Now, with the availability of hotspot Wi-Fi devices, users can connect multiple devices on the go without having to sacrifice on network speed.

Buying a hotspot Wi-Fi device therefore completely depends on the individual user's needs and requirement. Once the requirement is identified, choosing the right device becomes simpler. ●

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